

IT'S A NEW DAWN, BUT BE WARY OF QUICK FIXES

With the Asia Cup in 2025 and both the World Cup and Asian Games on the horizon in 2026, a triumphant ACT would ignite a **renewed sense** of confidence and momentum ahead of a busy season.

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When Hockey India named a "restructured" squad for the upcoming Women's Asian Champions Trophy (ACT) last month, it was notable that the federation acknowledged more than superficial changes in the side.

It wasn't just about the presence or absence of familiar faces; it was a statement indicating that, practically speaking, this was more than just a routine team announcement. Missing out on the Paris Olympics had disrupted all carefully laid plans for Indian women's hockey. Any future success now required, as a first step, acknowledging that it couldn't be business as usual.

The biggest surprise has been the exclusion of veteran Vandana Katariya from the squad. The only Indian woman with more than 300 international caps, Vandana missed the Olympic qualifier due to injury. Her absence was felt not only in scoring by a talented but inexperienced attack but also in the overall experience of the team. This is perhaps the first time Vandana has been excluded without an official injury update.

With senior players like Monika and the talented Nikki Pradhan also absent, the core of the Indian team has

been completely overhauled. While this speaks to chief coach Harendra Singh's future plans, it also takes the team into unknown territory. Conversely, the return of former captain Sushila Chanu, possibly to offset Nikki's absence in the midfield, suggests that the ACT will be less about national pride and more a testing ground for combinations in preparation for future, larger assignments.

Last year, when the Indian women's hockey team stood atop the podium in Ranchi, raising the Asian Champions Trophy high after an unbeaten run, it renewed hope

